

EMERGENCY SUB PLANS

MIDDLE SCHOOL ELA

VOLUME

2

★
10 LESSONS

Ten no-prep emergency lessons for the day you cannot be there. No novel required.



TIME-SAVING



NO PREP



ENGAGING



EFFECTIVE

- ✓ 10 complete lessons, one full class period each
- ✓ No novel, no textbook, no prep, no ELA background needed
- ✓ Every lesson has the words to say and a timing table
- ✓ All reading passages included and written for this pack
- ✓ Full answer keys with marking notes



DIGITAL VECTOR

Grades 6-8 • 57 pages • digitalvector.com.au

READ THIS FIRST • 90 SECONDS

Substitute Quick Start

You do not need to be an English teacher to run any lesson in this pack. Everything is here. Nothing needs to be prepared, looked up, or photocopied beyond the student pages for the lesson you were assigned.

What the classroom teacher has told you

Turn to the **Lesson Index** on the next page. The teacher has circled or written the lesson number for today. If nothing is marked, start at Lesson 11 and work forward. Any lesson can be taught on its own. They do not have to be done in order.

How every lesson is laid out

Page	What it is	What you do with it
Page 1	Teacher Briefing	Yours. Read it. It has the words to say and a timing table.
Page 2	Student page A	Copy for students. The text or stimulus they read.
Page 3	Student page B	Copy for students. The main task.
Page 4	Student page C	Copy for students. The writing task.
Page 5	Answer Key	Yours. Full answers plus notes on what counts as correct.

So the only photocopying is three pages per student

Pages 2, 3 and 4 of whichever lesson you are running. If the copier is down or there is no time, every lesson has a **No Copies** fallback printed in the Teacher Briefing that runs off the board and student notebook paper instead.

If things go sideways

They finish early

Every student page C ends with a boxed **Going Further** task. Point them at it. It is designed to absorb ten to fifteen extra minutes without needing you.

They say they cannot do it

The Teacher Briefing has a **Stuck?** line with one sentence to say out loud. It restarts almost every student without you knowing the content.

They will not settle

Read the opening script word for word. It is written to give the room something concrete to do inside the first two minutes, which is when classes are won or lost.

You have a short period

Each timing table has a **Short period** row. Cut the segment it names. The lesson still finishes properly.

Three things worth knowing before period one

You are allowed to read the answer key. It is written for someone who does not teach English, and every answer is worked out in full. Reading the key for the lesson before you start takes four minutes and is the single most useful thing you can do.

Not every question has one right answer. Where a question is open, the key describes what a strong response contains rather than pretending there is a single correct one. You can say that to students honestly.

You do not have to finish. Getting most of a class through most of a lesson properly is a better outcome than rushing all of it. Note where they got to and move on.

Leave a note for the teacher. On the back of any page, write the lesson number you ran, roughly how far the class got, and the names of anyone who did outstanding work or gave you trouble. That two-line note is worth more to the returning teacher than completed worksheets.

TEN LESSONS • ONE CLASS PERIOD EACH

Lesson Index

Circle the lesson the substitute should teach. Every lesson is independent. None of them requires a novel, a textbook, a device, or knowledge of what your class was doing last week.

No.	Lesson	Skill focus	Page
11	Headline Lab	Media literacy	5
12	The Fine Print	Persuasive technique	10
13	Two Sides, One Fact	Bias and source comparison	15
14	Poem in Plain Sight	Imagery and figurative language	20
15	Sound and Shape	Structure and line break	25
16	Make the Claim	Claim, evidence, reasoning	30
17	The Rebuttal	Counterargument and concession	35
18	Word Roots Detective	Morphology and vocabulary	40
19	Grammar in the Wild	Editing and sentence combining	45
20	The Silent Seminar	Written discussion	50

This is Volume 2. Nothing here repeats Volume 1.

Volume 1 covered narrative and informational reading with short response writing. Volume 2 deliberately moves into media literacy, poetry, argument, word study, editing and written discussion. If you own both, you have twenty lessons with no overlap and no repeated passage.

Choosing quickly

Loudest class

Lessons 11, 12 and 20. All three give students something to argue about on paper, which is quieter than it sounds.

Quietest option

Lessons 14, 18 and 19. Individual work, low talk, clear right answers, minimal supervision needed.

Best for a whole day

Run 16 then 17 back to back. The second builds directly on the first and together they make a full argument sequence.

Every passage, poem, advertisement, article and data set in this pack was written for this pack. There is no third party material, so nothing here will expire, break a link, or run into a permissions problem.

FOR THE CLASSROOM TEACHER

Before You Leave

Do this once, at the start of the year, and this pack works for every absence after that without you touching it again.

The five minute setup

Step	What to do
1	Print the whole pack once. Put it in a labeled folder in your top drawer or hand it to your team leader.
2	Print a class set of the three student pages for two lessons you like. Clip them to the front. That covers an unplanned absence with no copier access.
3	Write your room number, your bell times and your class sizes on the Quick Start page.
4	Add one line naming a reliable student in each class the substitute can ask about routines.
5	Tell your office where the folder is. That is the step people skip.

On the morning you are actually sick

Send one message: the lesson number and the room the folder is in. Nothing else is needed. That is the entire point of owning this.

Using these when you are not absent

These are built to survive a substitute, but they are ordinary good lessons and they hold up in your own room. Teachers use them for:

- ✓ **The day before a break**, when attendance is unpredictable and starting a unit is wasteful.
- ✓ **Standardized testing weeks**, when the timetable is shredded and classes arrive in fragments.
- ✓ **A student teacher's first solo lesson**, where a scripted plan with a real answer key removes most of the risk.
- ✓ **Reteaching**, when a skill from earlier in the year needs a second pass in a new context.
- ✓ **Early finishers and make up work**, since each lesson is self contained and can be handed to one student.

What the answer keys assume

Keys are written for a non specialist. Every answer is worked out in full rather than given as a single word, and where a question is open ended the key describes **what a strong response contains** rather than pretending there is one right answer. Marking notes flag the two or three wrong answers students actually give, so a substitute can respond to them without guessing.

If you are handing this to a student teacher

These work unusually well for a first solo lesson. The script removes the hardest part of the job, which is knowing what to say in the first two minutes, and the answer key means the supervising teacher can leave the room without the lesson depending on subject expertise. Lessons 18 and 19 are the safest starting points, since both have clear right answers and run quietly.

Grades 6 to 8. Reading levels sit in the middle of that band. For a stronger class, the Going Further boxes carry the lift. For a struggling class, the Teacher Briefing names which section to drop.

What this lesson is

Students read three reports of the same town council vote, written by three different outlets. Every fact in all three is true. The reports still leave completely different impressions. Students work out how that happened, then do it themselves.

Skill

Media literacy. Recognizing how framing changes a story.

They hand in

A completed comparison grid, six written answers, and three original headlines.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 5	Hand out pages. Read the opening script. Students read Report 1 only, silently.
5 to 12	Students read Reports 2 and 3. Nothing to write yet.
12 to 25	Students fill the comparison grid on page B.
25 to 42	Questions 1 to 4 on page B, then 5 and 6 at the top of page C.
42 to 52	Page C. Students write the same school event three ways.
52 to end	Volunteers read one version aloud. Ask the class which outlet it sounds like.
Short period	Cut the grid. Go from reading straight to questions 1, 2 and 3 on page B.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"Three reporters went to the same meeting on the same night. Nobody lied. Nobody made anything up. Every single fact you are about to read is true."

"By the end of this period I want you to be able to explain how three true reports can leave you with three completely different ideas about what happened. Read Report 1 first. Do not write anything yet."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"Here is the thing to notice. Look at what each headline chose to put first. A headline has about eight words. Whatever the writer puts in those eight words is what most people will remember, because most people never read past them."

Stuck?

Say: "Find one fact that appears in all three reports. Just one. Start there." The vote count of five to four is in every report and finding it unlocks the rest.

No copies? Run it this way

Write the three headlines on the board and read the three reports aloud, twice. Students rule three columns in their notebooks and take notes under each. Questions 1, 2, 3 and 6 all work from board headlines alone.

Watch for

Students often decide one report is "the lying one." It is not. Push back with: *point to a sentence that is actually false*. They will not find one. That is the lesson. Selection and word choice do the work, not lying.

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Three reports, one meeting

On Tuesday night the Riverton City Council voted on the future of the Bell Street Skate Park. Three different outlets covered it. Read all three before you write anything.

REPORT 1 The Riverton Daily • local newspaper

Council Approves Parking Lot on Bell Street Skate Park Site

The Riverton City Council voted 5 to 4 on Tuesday night to close the Bell Street Skate Park and build a 40 space parking lot on the site. The project will cost \$310,000, and construction is scheduled to begin in March.

About 60 residents attended. Twenty two spoke during public comment, 18 of them against the closure. Council member Ellen Vance said downtown businesses have raised parking concerns for four years. Council member Marcus Reid, who voted against the plan, noted that the park was built in 2009 with a state youth grant and that the nearest skate park is 14 miles away in Ashgrove.

REPORT 2 Channel 8 Action News • evening broadcast

SHUT OUT: City Paves Over the Only Free Place Riverton Kids Have Left

Riverton teenagers are losing the one place in town that never asked them for a dollar. In a packed and heated meeting Tuesday night, the council narrowly pushed through a plan to tear out the beloved Bell Street Skate Park and pave it over for parking.

Eighteen residents stood up and asked the council to reconsider. They were ignored. The nearest skate park is now a 14 mile trip, and for a kid without a ride, that may as well be the moon. Demolition crews arrive in March.

REPORT 3 Riverton Business Weekly

Downtown Parking Relief Approved After Four Year Push

Downtown Riverton will gain 40 parking spaces next year following a council vote Tuesday evening. The \$310,000 project converts an underused lot on Bell Street and is expected to ease the congestion merchants have reported since 2021.

Council member Ellen Vance, who championed the measure, said the decision reflects four years of consistent feedback from business owners. The vote was 5 to 4. Work begins in March.

Before you turn the page

Every sentence in all three reports is factually true. None of these reporters made anything up. As you read again, keep two questions in your head: **what did this writer put first**, and **what did this writer decide not to mention**. Those two choices, made before a single word is written, do almost all the work of shaping what a reader ends up believing.

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 1 • The comparison grid

Fill in every box. Short phrases are fine.

	Riverton Daily	Channel 8	Business Weekly
The one fact the headline picked			

How it wants you to feel

A fact it leaves out

Who it is written for

Part 2 • Questions

1. All three reports describe the same vote. Write what happened as a plain fact in one sentence, using no words that carry feeling. 2 marks

2. Report 3 calls the site “an underused lot.” What does that phrase leave out, and why might a business paper choose those words? 3 marks

3. Report 2 says the residents “were ignored.” Is that a fact or an interpretation? Explain how you can tell. 3 marks

4. Find one word in Report 2 that pushes the reader toward a feeling. Write it down, then replace it with a neutral word that keeps the meaning. 2 marks

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

5. Which report gives a reader the most of what they would need in order to decide what they think about the vote? Give two reasons. 3 marks

6. Each headline chose a different fact to lead with. Name the fact each one picked. 3 marks

Part 3 • Now you do it

The event

Your school removes the two vending machines from the cafeteria and installs a free water refill station in their place. The machines earned the school \$4,200 last year, which paid for sports equipment. A survey found 71 percent of students used the machines at least weekly.

Write a headline and a two sentence report for each outlet below. Use only facts from the box. You may choose which facts to include and which to leave out.

A • The school newsletter, written by the principal

B • A student reporter who is annoyed about it

C • The county health department newsletter

Going Further

Take Report 2 from page A and rewrite it as straight news, the way the Riverton Daily would run it. Keep every fact. Remove every word that tells the reader how to feel. Then underline the words you had to cut and count them.

Grid, expected responses

	Riverton Daily	Channel 8	Business Weekly
Headline fact	Parking lot approved on the site	Kids lose a free space	Downtown gains parking
Feeling	Neutral	Angry, pro teen	Pleased, relieved
Leaves out	Very little	The parking problem	That it is a skate park
Written for	Residents	Families, broad TV	Business owners

1

On Tuesday the Riverton City Council voted 5 to 4 to replace the Bell Street Skate Park with a 40 space parking lot costing \$310,000, with construction starting in March.

Accept any version with the result and the decision and no loaded words. Narrowly is fine, bulldoze is not.

2

It omits that the site is a working skate park built with a public youth grant. A business paper writes for readers who judge land by its commercial use, not by who plays on it.

Two marks for the omission, one for the audience reason.

3

Interpretation. The fact is that 18 spoke against and the council approved it anyway. *Ignored* adds an unverifiable claim about attitude, and a council that listened carefully then disagreed would look identical.

The test: could two honest witnesses disagree about it? If yes, it is interpretation.

4

Any of **beloved, tear out, pave over, packed, heated, pushed through, begged, ignored**. Neutral swaps: *well used, remove, build on, full, lengthy, approved, asked, not persuaded*.

One mark for the word, one for a swap that keeps the meaning.

5

Report 1. It alone gives both the reason for the decision and the reasons against, plus the vote, cost and timeline, so a reader can weigh it rather than be told the conclusion.

Another report can earn full marks if argued with two reasons from the text.

6

Daily: the decision. Channel 8: the loss to young people. Business Weekly: the parking gain.

One mark each.

Part 3 marking

Not marking writing quality. **A** should lead on health or wellbeing and omit the \$4,200. **B** should lead on the lost sports funding and the 71 percent. **C** should lead on the water station and omit the money. If the three versions are hard to tell apart, ask the student which fact they left out of each. That question fixes it.

What this lesson is

Three advertisements, each with a claim that sounds impressive and fine print that quietly takes most of it back. Students match the claim to the technique, then write an ad of their own twice, once dishonestly and once honestly.

Skill

Persuasive technique. Reading advertising claims against their fine print.

They hand in

A completed technique table, five written answers, and two versions of an original ad.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 4	Hand out pages. Read the opening script.
4 to 12	Students read the three ads on page A, fine print included.
12 to 24	Students complete the technique table on page B.
24 to 40	Questions 1 to 3 on page B, then 4 and 5 at the top of page C.
40 to 52	Page C. Students write the dishonest ad, then the honest one.
52 to end	Read two or three dishonest versions aloud. Class names the technique used.
Short period	Cut the technique table. Read the ads, then do questions 2 and 3 and the page C writing.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"Everything on this page is legal. Companies are allowed to say all of it. That is what makes it worth studying."

"Read the big print first, the way you normally would. Then read the small print at the bottom of each ad. Notice what happens to the promise when you do."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"Watch for two words in particular. Up to and helps. Up to twelve percent faster includes zero percent faster. Helps you train harder is not a claim that it works, it is a claim that it assists something. Both are legally safe and both are close to meaningless."

Stuck?

Say: "Cover the small print with your hand. What do you think the ad promised? Now uncover it. What did it actually promise?" The gap between those two is the answer to nearly every question on the page.

No copies? Run it this way

Write the three headline claims and their fine print on the board, one ad at a time. Students copy each pair into their notebooks and write one sentence saying what the fine print takes back. Questions 1 to 4 work from board notes. Page C needs no handout at all.

Watch for

Some students conclude that all advertising is lying and stop thinking. Redirect them: *none of these ads is illegal, so what exactly is the technique?* The goal is to name the move, not to be cynical about it.

Name

Class

Date

Three advertisements

Read the large claim first. Then read the small print underneath it.

AD 1 Energy drink, full page magazine

8 out of 10 athletes say VOLT RUSH helps them train harder.*

Get the edge. Get VOLT RUSH.

*Based on a survey of 10 athletes sponsored by Volt Rush Beverages. Individual results vary. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure or prevent any condition.

AD 2 Running shoe, online banner

Run up to 12% faster in the new STRIDE X.†

Engineered for speed. Trusted by runners everywhere.

†Based on laboratory testing of one wear tester on a treadmill at a controlled incline, compared against that tester's own previous footwear. Not a guarantee of individual performance.

AD 3 Tutoring service, mailed flyer

Your child will improve by a full letter grade. Guaranteed.‡

Don't let your child fall behind. Every day you wait is a day they lose.

‡Guarantee applies to students completing 40 or more sessions with attendance of 95% or above, in the subject enrolled, within one academic year. Where the guarantee is not met, remedy is provided as service credit only. No cash refunds.

Six techniques you will need

Weasel word	A word that softens a promise until it cannot be tested. <i>Up to. Helps. May. As much as.</i>
Tiny sample	A percentage built on so few people that it means nothing.
Paid source	The people who supplied the evidence were paid by the seller.
Loaded condition	A guarantee that is real, but only under conditions most people will not meet.
Fear appeal	Pressure created by suggesting something bad happens if you wait.
Vague authority	Approval implied by no one in particular. <i>Trusted by runners everywhere.</i>

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 1 • Name the technique

Quote the words from the ad, then name the technique from the list on page A. Each ad uses more than one.

Ad	Words from the ad	Technique
1		
1		
2		
2		
3		
3		

Part 2 • Questions

1. Ad 1 says 8 out of 10 athletes. Explain why that number is far weaker evidence than it looks. 3 marks

2. Rewrite the claim in Ad 2 so that it is completely honest. You may make it longer. 3 marks

3. The guarantee in Ad 3 is genuine. Explain how a company could offer it and still expect to pay it out very rarely. 3 marks

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

4. Find the sentence in Ad 3 that uses fear rather than evidence. Write it out and explain what it wants a parent³ marks to feel.

5. Of the three ads, which one would you say is the most misleading? Name it and give two reasons. There is no⁴ marks single correct answer, so your reasons carry the marks.

Part 3 • Write it twice

Your product

A plain wooden pencil. It costs 20 cents. It writes. It is the same as every other pencil. Choose a brand name.

Version 1 • Use at least three techniques from page A

Write a headline claim, one line of supporting text, and a line of fine print that quietly takes the claim back.

Techniques I used:

Version 2 • Now sell the same pencil honestly

No weasel words. No fine print. Every claim must be one you could prove.

Going Further

Which version was harder to write? Write three sentences explaining why. Most people find the honest one harder, and the reason for that is worth thinking about carefully.

The Fine Print

Part 1 • Technique table

Ad	Words	Technique
1	"helps them train harder"	Weasel word
1	"survey of 10 athletes"	Tiny sample
1	"sponsored by Volt Rush"	Paid source
2	"up to 12% faster"	Weasel word
2	"Trusted by runners everywhere"	Vague authority
2	"one wear tester"	Tiny sample
3	"40 or more sessions...95%"	Loaded condition
3	"Every day you wait"	Fear appeal

Any six correct pairings is full marks.

1

Ten people means each is worth ten percentage points, so one changed answer makes it 7 out of 10. They were paid by the seller. And what they agreed with, *helps train harder*, is not a measurable outcome to begin with.

One mark each for sample size, paid source, and the softness of the claim.

2

In one laboratory test, a single runner on a treadmill ran up to 12 percent faster in STRIDE X than in their own previous shoes. Your results will probably differ.

Marks for naming the sample as one person, the setting as a treadmill, and keeping the comparison honest. Deleting the claim is not the task.

3

The conditions do the work. Forty sessions is a large commitment, 95 percent attendance means missing three voids it, it covers one subject in one year, and the payout is service credit rather than cash.

Two marks for two disqualifying conditions, one for credit rather than cash.

4

"Don't let your child fall behind. Every day you wait is a day they lose." It makes a parent feel anxious and responsible, and turns waiting into an active choice to harm their child. No evidence, only urgency.

One mark for the sentence, two for the feeling.

5

Any of the three, argued well. Ad 3 targets parental anxiety with an unreachable guarantee. Ad 1 dresses ten paid opinions as research. Ad 2 is true even if the shoe does nothing.

Mark the reasoning, not the choice. Two reasons drawn from the ad text for full marks.

Part 3 marking

Version 1 needs three named techniques and fine print that genuinely retracts the claim. The common miss is fine print that repeats the claim instead of limiting it. Version 2 should be short and dull, because a 20 cent pencil has nothing provable to say. That is the correct outcome, not a failed attempt. If an honest version is still exciting, ask the student to prove one sentence of it.

What this lesson is

Two pieces about the same school phone policy, one by a principal and one by a student. Both are honest. Neither includes all the evidence. Students discover that the strongest form of bias is not lying, it is choosing which true things to mention.

Skill

Detecting bias through selection.
Separating fact from interpretation.

They hand in

A fact and opinion sort, a loaded language hunt, five answers, and a neutral summary.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 4	Hand out pages. Read the opening script.
4 to 13	Students read both pieces on page A and the shared evidence box beneath them.
13 to 26	Page B. Students complete the fact and opinion sort and the loaded language hunt.
26 to 40	Question 1 on page B, then questions 2 to 4 at the top of page C.
40 to 53	Page C. Students write a neutral summary both writers would accept as accurate.
53 to end	Read two summaries aloud. Ask: could you tell which side the writer is on?
Short period	Cut the loaded language hunt. Go from the sort straight to page C.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"Two people wrote about the same school policy. One is the principal, one is a student. Underneath both pieces is a box listing every fact that was actually available to both of them."

"Your job is not to decide who is right about phones. Your job is to work out which facts each writer used and which ones they quietly walked past."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"Go back to the evidence box and put a P next to every fact the principal used and an S next to every fact the student used. Some facts get both letters. Some get none. The ones that get only one letter are where the argument is really happening."

Stuck?

Say: "Pick any one fact from the box. Which writer would want you to know it? Why?" One fact at a time is enough to get moving.

No copies? Run it this way

Read both pieces aloud twice, then dictate the eight facts from the evidence box. Students rule two columns headed PRINCIPAL and STUDENT and sort the facts into them, with a middle column for facts both used. Then set page C as the written task.

Watch for

Students want to award a winner. Hold the line: the task is to describe the technique. A useful reframe is *both of these would pass a fact check, so what exactly is the problem?*

The same policy, two pieces

In September, Ashgrove Middle School began requiring students to lock their phones in pouches during class time. Both pieces below were published in November.

PIECE A Principal's newsletter to families

A Calmer Building

I want to share some encouraging news. Since we introduced phone pouches on September 8, discipline referrals have fallen from 94 in the first quarter last year to 61 this year. That is a drop of more than a third, and it represents dozens of students who stayed in class instead of sitting in my office.

Our library has seen checkouts rise by 18 percent. Teachers tell me that hallway conversations have returned. This was not an easy change to ask of our community, and I am grateful for the patience families have shown. The evidence is clear, and we will be continuing the policy into the spring.

PIECE B Student op-ed, the Ashgrove Beacon

Treated Like Suspects

When the school surveyed us about the pouch policy, 300 students responded and 62 percent said they opposed it. That number has not appeared in a single newsletter sent home. Instead we have been handed a policy nobody asked for and told to be grateful.

Two families have already reported being unable to reach their children during the school day. Fourteen pouches have been damaged, and the school is quietly replacing them at six dollars each rather than admitting the system is failing. We are not a discipline problem to be managed. We are 1,040 people who were never actually asked.

The evidence box • everything both writers had access to

- 1 The policy began September 8. Phones are locked in pouches during class time only.
- 2 The school has 1,040 students.
- 3 Discipline referrals fell from 94 in the first quarter last year to 61 this year.
- 4 A survey received 300 student responses. Of those, 62 percent opposed the policy.
- 5 Library checkouts rose 18 percent.
- 6 Two parents reported being unable to reach their child during the day.
- 7 Fourteen pouches were damaged and replaced at a cost of six dollars each.
- 8 Staff reported an increase in cafeteria noise complaints.

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 1 • Who used what

Write **P** if only the principal used the fact, **S** if only the student used it, **B** if both did, and **N** if neither did.

#	Fact	P/S/B/ N
1	Policy start date and scope	
2	1,040 students enrolled	
3	Referrals fell from 94 to 61	
4	62 percent of 300 respondents opposed	
5	Library checkouts rose 18 percent	
6	Two parents could not reach a child	
7	Fourteen pouches damaged	
8	Cafeteria noise complaints rose	

Part 2 • Loaded language

Find two phrases in each piece that tell you how to feel rather than what happened.

Piece	Phrase	What it wants you to feel
A		
A		
B		
B		

Part 3 • Questions

1. Which two facts from the evidence box did **neither** writer use? Suggest why each one was left out.

4 marks

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

2. The survey had 300 responses from a school of 1,040. Explain one reason that matters when you read the 62³ marks percent figure.

3. The principal writes “the evidence is clear.” Using the evidence box, explain why that statement is doing more³ marks work than it should.

4. Both writers use real numbers. Explain how a reader could be misled by either piece without either writer stating anything false. 4 marks

Part 4 • The neutral summary

Your task

Write one paragraph of five to seven sentences summarizing the situation. It must use at least **five** facts from the evidence box, including at least one that helps each side. A reader must not be able to tell what you personally think about phone pouches.

Going Further

Underline every adjective in your paragraph. For each one, ask whether it describes something measurable or something you are inviting the reader to feel. Cross out the ones in the second group and check whether the paragraph lost any real information.

Part 1 • Sort

#	Fact	Ans	Note
1	Start date and scope	B	Both name it
2	1,040 students	S	Used to stress scale
3	Referrals 94 to 61	P	Strongest for the policy
4	62 percent opposed	S	Strongest against it
5	Library up 18 percent	P	
6	Two parents blocked	S	
7	Fourteen pouches damaged	S	
8	Cafeteria noise	N	Helps neither cleanly

Fact 2 is often marked B. Accept B only if the student can point to where the principal uses it. He does not.

Part 2 • Loaded language

Piece	Phrase	Pull
A	"encouraging news"	Frames the result before giving it
A	"the evidence is clear"	Closes the question down
B	"Treated Like Suspects"	Casts students as accused
B	"quietly replacing"	Implies concealment

1

Fact 8 and, for the principal, fact 2. Cafeteria noise cuts both ways, since more talking supports his claim about conversation returning while also sounding like a new problem. He omits the enrollment figure because naming 1,040 invites the reader to notice only 300 were surveyed.

Two marks for identifying them, two for plausible reasoning. It wasn't important earns nothing.

2

300 of 1,040 is under a third, and students who chose to respond are likely those who felt strongest, usually the most opposed. So 62 percent of respondents is not 62 percent of the school.

Full marks need the respondents versus school distinction.

3

It is not clear. Referrals and library use moved his way, but most respondents opposed the policy, two families reported a contact problem, and equipment is being damaged. Referrals could also have fallen for unrelated reasons.

Two marks for contrary evidence, one for noting a change over time does not prove a cause.

4

Each writer selects only supporting facts, so a reader of one piece builds a picture from true statements that is still incomplete. A parent reading only A concludes the policy is working and uncontroversial; a student reading only B concludes it achieved nothing. Neither was lied to.

The central idea: selection, not falsehood, does the misleading.

Part 4 marking • the neutral summary

Five facts, at least one per side, attribution rather than assertion (*the school reports, students surveyed said*), and no adjective that grades the policy. Quick test to say aloud: if you can guess the writer's opinion, it has not met the brief.

What this lesson is

Two short original poems, both set somewhere ordinary. Students identify simile, metaphor, personification and sensory image, then use a supplied frame to write their own. No prior poetry knowledge is needed and the four terms are defined on the page.

Skill

Imagery and figurative language. Reading a poem for what it shows rather than what it means.

They hand in

An annotated poem, eight written answers, and an original eight line poem.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 4	Hand out pages. Read the opening script.
4 to 10	Read Poem 1 aloud twice. Students follow along. Then they read Poem 2 silently.
10 to 22	Students annotate Poem 1 using the four codes on page A.
22 to 38	Questions 1 to 5 on page B, then 6 to 8 at the top of page C.
38 to 53	Page C. Students write their own poem using the frame.
53 to end	Invite two or three volunteers to read one line each, not the whole poem.
Short period	Skip Poem 2. Annotate Poem 1, do questions 1 to 5 on page B, then write.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"Neither of these poems rhymes and neither of them is about anything unusual. One is set in a laundromat. One is set in the back row of a classroom."

"I am going to read the first one aloud twice. The first time, just listen. The second time, underline any line that puts a picture in your head."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"A quick check. Find the line about the clock. It says the clock is a slow animal. A clock is not an animal. So why does that work better than saying the clock was slow? Talk to the person next to you for thirty seconds."

Stuck?

Say: "Forget the terms. Just point to the line you can see most clearly in your head, and tell me what you see." Naming the device is easier once they have described the image.

No copies? Run it this way

Write Poem 1 on the board while students copy it into notebooks with a blank line between each poem line, which gives them annotation space. Read it aloud twice. Questions 1 to 6 work from Poem 1 alone. The writing frame on page C can be dictated in four lines.

Watch for

The most common error is treating every comparison as a simile. Remind them of the test: *simile uses like or as, metaphor does not*. The second most common is hunting for a hidden message. Redirect to what the poem actually shows.

Two poems

The four codes you will use

SIM Comparison using *like* or *as*

PER A non living thing given life

MET Says one thing is another

IMG A detail you can see, hear or smell

POEM 1

Laundromat, Nine O'Clock

1

The dryers turn like slow gray planets,
each one holding somebody's week.

A woman folds a shirt in thirds,
sharp as a letter she will not send.

2

The vending machine hums its one note.
Somebody's kid draws on the fogged glass,
a house, a sun, a stick figure family,
then wipes it out before anyone can see.

3

Outside, the parking lot is a black lake.
Inside, everything smells like heat and soap
and the particular patience of people
who have nowhere better to be at nine o'clock.

POEM 2

The Last Row

1

Back here the world arrives secondhand,
filtered through forty heads and a whiteboard glare.
The clock is a slow animal on the wall.
I have learned the exact weight of a minute.

2

My name comes down the aisle like weather,
sometimes reaching me, sometimes not.
I keep a small country in my notebook margin:
mountains, a river, one road going out.

Annotate Poem 1 now. Write SIM, MET, PER or IMG next to at least six lines. Some lines carry more than one code.

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

How to answer these

Every question asks two things: **what the words say**, and **what effect they have**. Quote the line first, then explain. An answer that only quotes has done half of it, and an answer that only explains leaves the marker guessing which line you meant.

1. Copy the simile in stanza 1 of Poem 1. What does comparing dryers to planets suggest about how they move ^{3 marks} and how long the wait feels?

2. “each one holding somebody's week.” What is actually inside the dryer, and what does the word *week* tell you ^{3 marks} about the people in the laundromat?

3. A shirt is folded “sharp as a letter she will not send.” What does this comparison suggest about the woman, ^{3 marks} beyond how she folds?

4. The child draws a house, a sun and a family, then wipes it away. Suggest what this detail adds to the poem. ^{3 marks}

5. Find the metaphor in stanza 3 and explain what it makes the parking lot feel like. ^{3 marks}

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

6. In Poem 2, the clock is “a slow animal.” Explain why that is more effective than writing *the clock was slow*. 3 marks

7. “My name comes down the aisle like weather.” Explain what this tells you about the speaker's experience of the classroom. 3 marks

8. The speaker keeps “a small country” in the notebook margin, with “one road going out.” What does that last detail suggest? 3 marks

Part 2 • Write your own

The frame

Choose **one ordinary place where people wait**. A bus stop, a waiting room, a checkout line, a car at pickup, a hallway before the bell. Write eight lines. You must include at least one simile, one metaphor and one sensory image, and you must **not** name a feeling anywhere in the poem. No *sad, bored, happy, lonely*. Show it instead.

My place:

Label your own poem: write SIM, MET and IMG in the margin beside the lines that use them.

Going Further

Go back and cut two lines from your poem. Any two. Read what is left aloud. Poems very often improve when they lose their weakest lines, and finding out which two you can lose is the real skill.

Poem in Plain Sight

Annotation, Poem 1

dryers like slow gray planets	draws on the fogged glass	SIM
holding somebody's week	parking lot is a black lake	MET
sharp as a letter she will not send	smells like heat and soap	SIM
vending machine hums its one note	the particular patience of people	PER

1

"The dryers turn like slow gray planets." Planets turn steadily and far too slowly to watch, so the machines feel unhurried and inevitable and the wait feels long.

One mark for the quotation, two for the effect. Accept slowness or scale.

2

Actual clothes. Calling them a *week* says these are people washing everything they own at once, on a schedule, because they have no machine at home.

Clothes alone earns one mark.

3

She is precise and controlled, and perhaps holding something back. A letter you will not send is one you wrote and kept, so the feelings are folded away rather than expressed.

One mark for the double sense of sharp.

4

The child draws an ideal family and erases it before it can be seen, suggesting either something wished for rather than had, or a habit of hiding what you want.

Reward answers that connect the erasing to the setting.

5

"the parking lot is a black lake." The asphalt looks wet and reflective under the lights, making outside feel deep and cold against the warm interior.

One mark for the metaphor, two for the contrast.

6

An animal has a will, so the slowness feels deliberate, as though the clock is refusing to move. *The clock was slow* describes the clock; *a slow animal* describes what watching it feels like.

Full marks need the idea of intention or resistance.

7

Weather arrives without being aimed at anyone and sometimes reaches you, so the speaker is rarely addressed directly and does not expect to be.

Two marks for not being singled out, one for the sense of distance.

8

It suggests a wish to leave. The single road out turns the daydream from a distraction into something closer to a plan.

Answers that ignore the road earn one mark.

Part 2 marking

Mark against the frame, not taste. Eight lines, one simile, one metaphor, one sensory image, all labeled in the margin, and no named feelings. Enforce the no feelings rule; it is what forces the imagery to work. If a student wrote *the waiting room was boring*, ask what boring looks like in that room.

What this lesson is

One set of words is printed twice in two different shapes. Nothing else changes. Students work out why the two versions read differently, then learn what enjambment does, then re-line a prose paragraph themselves and defend three of their break choices.

Skill

Structure. How line breaks and shape change meaning without changing words.

They hand in

Two comparison answers, six written responses, and a prose paragraph re-lined as a poem.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 4	Hand out pages. Read the opening script.
4 to 12	Students read Text 1 in both shapes on page A, then Text 2.
12 to 24	Questions 1 to 4 on page B, comparing the two shapes.
24 to 38	The three shape task on page B, then questions 5 and 6 on page C.
38 to 53	Page C. Students re-line the prose paragraph and justify three breaks.
53 to end	Two volunteers read their versions aloud. Ask the class where the pauses landed.
Short period	Cut Text 2 and questions 5 and 6. Go from question 4 straight to page C.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"On the first page you will see the same nineteen words printed twice. Not similar words. The same words, in the same order, with nothing added and nothing removed."

"The only difference is where the lines end. Read both. If they feel different to you, that difference was made entirely by white space, and today we work out how."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"Here is the rule that explains most of it. A reader pauses slightly at the end of every line, whether or not there is punctuation there. So a poet choosing where to break a line is choosing where you take a breath, and choosing which word gets left hanging at the edge."

Stuck?

Say: "Read version A out loud in your head and tap the desk once at the end of every line. Now do version B. Which one felt slower?" Almost every student says A, and that answer is the beginning of the whole lesson.

No copies? Run it this way

Write Text 1 on the board in shape A. Students copy it. Then rub it out and rewrite the identical words in shape B. The act of watching it change shape is more effective than the handout. Dictate the paragraph on page C for the re-lining task.

Watch for

Students often say version B is "more normal." Accept it, then push: normal for what? B reads like speech, A reads like someone thinking. Neither is better, and saying so out loud prevents the lesson collapsing into which one is right.

Text 1 • the same words, twice**SHAPE A**

The bus
is late
again
and the rain
has found
the hole
in my shoe.

SHAPE B

The bus is late again and the rain
has found the hole in my shoe.

Nineteen words in each. Same words. Same order. Only the line endings differ.

One term you need

Enjambment is when a sentence runs past the end of a line instead of stopping there. The reader pauses at the line break anyway, so for a moment the incomplete line means something on its own, and then the next line changes it. Poets use this to make a reader think one thing and then immediately think another.

TEXT 2**What I Said at Dinner**

I told my mother everything was
fine, which was true
the way a bridge is safe
until the day it isn't.

She passed the potatoes.

I passed the test
of looking like a person
who eats dinner.

Before you turn the page: read Text 2 once stopping firmly at the end of every line, even where there is no punctuation. Then read it again ignoring the line breaks completely. Notice that you understood two different things.

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

1. Which shape of Text 1 feels slower to read? Explain what causes that, given the words are identical.

3 marks

2. In Shape A, the word **again** sits alone on a line. Explain what that does to the word.

3 marks

3. Shape B ends its first line on the word **rain**. Explain what a reader expects at that moment, and what they get instead.

3 marks

4. In Text 2, line 1 ends on the word **was**. Explain what the reader briefly thinks the sentence is going to say, and how line 2 changes it.

3 marks

Part 2 • Break it yourself

One sentence, three shapes

I said I would call her back and then I did not.

Set this sentence three different ways. Change nothing but the line breaks. Under each version, write the one word you left at the end of a line on purpose.

Shape 1

Key word:

Shape 2

Key word:

Shape 3

Key word:

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

5. “which was true / the way a bridge is safe / until the day it isn’t.” Explain what this comparison says about the speaker’s *fine*. ^{3 marks}

6. The second stanza puts **She passed the potatoes** next to **I passed the test**. Explain what the repeated word *passed* is doing. ^{3 marks}

Part 2 • Re-line it yourself

The paragraph

The last bus leaves at ten forty. I know because I have missed it twice. Both times I walked the two miles home along the highway with my headphones off so I could hear the cars. It is not a bad walk. It is just long.

Rewrite these exact words as a poem. **Change nothing.** No word may be added, removed or reordered. You control only the line breaks and the stanza breaks. Aim for eight to twelve lines and use enjambment at least twice.

Defend three breaks

For three line endings, write the last word and one sentence on why you ended there.

Going Further

Now break the same paragraph a second way, deliberately badly. End lines on words like *the*, *at* and *so*. Read it aloud. Write two sentences on what makes those breaks feel wrong, because being able to say why something fails is how you learn to make it work.

Sound and Shape

1

Shape A. Each line break creates a small pause, and Shape A has seven line endings across nineteen words while Shape B has only two. More breaks means more pauses, so the same sentence takes longer and each fragment gets weighed on its own. Shape A reads like someone thinking in pieces. Shape B reads closer to ordinary speech.

One mark for naming A, two for connecting the number of breaks to the number of pauses. Students who say “A has more lines” without explaining why that slows reading get one mark.

2

Isolating *again* gives it a full pause on both sides, so it lands as its own complaint rather than as an unstressed part of the sentence. It shifts the meaning from a bus being late to this being a repeated, tiring pattern in the speaker's life.

Full marks need the idea of repetition or accumulated frustration, not just “it stands out.”

3

Ending on *rain* lets the reader briefly take rain as the subject of something larger, perhaps the weather turning or the day getting worse. The next line delivers something much smaller and more personal, a hole in a shoe. The break sets up a big expectation and pays off with a small, specific detail.

Accept any reasonable expectation for line 1 as long as the answer identifies the shift to something smaller and more concrete.

4

Ending on *was* leaves the sentence incomplete, and for a moment the reader supplies something honest, since *everything was* sounds like the beginning of a real admission. Line 2 arrives with *fine*, which is the opposite, and the delay makes the word land as clearly false. The line break does the work that a whole sentence of explanation would otherwise do.

Two marks for what the reader expects, one for how fine is undercut by arriving late.

5

It says the speaker's *fine* is technically true but not reliable. A bridge is genuinely safe every day until the day it collapses, and it never announces which day that is. So the speaker is admitting that saying *fine* is accurate right now while quietly warning that the situation carries the same hidden risk.

Full marks need the idea of technically true but temporary or unreliable. Students who only say “she is lying” earn one mark, because the poem is careful to say it was true.

6

Repeating *passed* connects an ordinary dinner action to the speaker's private effort. The mother's passing takes no thought at all. The speaker's is an examination that has to be gotten through. Placing them in consecutive lines makes the reader hear how much work is going into looking normal while nothing visible is happening.

Two marks for the contrast between effortless and effortful, one for noticing that this is a pun on two meanings of the same word.

Part 2 marking • the re-lined paragraph

There is no single correct version. Check three things and mark those. Every word from the original is present, unchanged and in order. There are at least two genuine enjambments, meaning a sentence that runs over a line break. And the three defended breaks give a reason connected to emphasis, pause or surprise, rather than “it looked right there.”

A strong version usually breaks after *ten forty*, *twice*, *walked*, *off* or *not*. Ending a line on *not* is the strongest available move in the paragraph, because it leaves the reader holding a negative with nothing attached to it yet. If a student found that one, say so out loud.

What this lesson is

Students receive a genuine two sided data set about school start times, sort the evidence, commit to a claim, and write one paragraph in claim, evidence, reasoning order. The reasoning step is the one this lesson is really about, and it is the one students skip.

Skill

Argument. Building a claim supported by evidence and explicit reasoning.

They hand in

An evidence sort, a completed claim frame, four answers, and one full argument paragraph.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 4	Hand out pages. Read the opening script.
4 to 12	Students read the briefing note and the eight findings on page A.
12 to 22	Students sort all eight findings into supports later start, supports current start, or depends.
22 to 34	Students commit to a claim and complete the frame on page B.
34 to 40	Questions 1 to 3 at the top of page C.
40 to 54	Page C. Full paragraph, written in the boxed structure.
54 to end	Ask for a show of hands on each claim, then ask one student from the smaller group to read their reasoning sentence only.
Short period	Cut questions 1 to 3. Sort, frame, then write.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"A claim is what you think. Evidence is the fact you point at. Reasoning is the sentence that explains why that fact supports what you think. Almost everybody does the first two and skips the third."

"The data on page A does not point cleanly one way. That is deliberate. A real argument is one where the other side has something to work with."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"Test your reasoning sentence with this. Could somebody agree that your fact is true and still disagree with your claim? If yes, your reasoning sentence has not done its job yet. It has to close that gap."

Stuck?

Say: **"Pick the one finding that annoys you most. Now argue the side it does not support."** Giving a student the harder side removes the pressure of being right and usually starts them writing.

No copies? Run it this way

Dictate the eight findings, numbered. Students rule three columns headed LATER, CURRENT and DEPENDS and sort them. Write the three sentence frame on the board. The paragraph is written in notebooks with no handout needed.

Watch for

The universal error is evidence with no reasoning, for example *School should start later because 68 percent of students get under eight hours of sleep.* That is a claim and evidence welded together. Ask: *and why does that mean the start time should move?* The answer to that question is the missing sentence.

Should Ashgrove Middle School move its start time?

The situation

Ashgrove Middle School currently starts at 7:45 a.m. The district has asked the school community to comment on a proposal to move the start to 8:30 a.m., with the end of the day moving 45 minutes later to match. The findings below were gathered by the district over one school year. They are all accurate.

The eight findings

#	Finding
1	In a survey of 412 students, 68 percent reported fewer than eight hours of sleep on a school night. The recommended amount for this age group is nine to twelve hours.
2	Fourteen percent of students hold an after school job. Most of those shifts begin between 4:00 and 4:30 p.m.
3	Kelsey County schools moved to an 8:30 start three years ago. Their tardy rate fell 22 percent.
4	Kelsey County also recorded a 9 percent rise in students absent from the final period of the day.
5	Three of Ashgrove's eleven bus routes are shared with the high school and would need to be re-timed. The district estimates one additional bus would be required, at roughly \$48,000 per year.
6	Athletic practice would move from 3:15 to 5:00 p.m., affecting 210 students. Two of the four practice fields have no lighting.
7	Teacher sick leave at Ashgrove is 11 percent above the district average. The district has not investigated a cause.
8	Of 260 parents surveyed, 54 percent supported the later start, 31 percent opposed it, and 15 percent were unsure.

Before you sort

A finding is not evidence until somebody uses it for something. The same fact can support opposite claims depending on the sentence you attach to it. Finding 4, the rise in last period absence, is the clearest example on this page: it can be read as proof the change created a new problem, or as proof the old problem simply became visible. Decide which reading you can defend.

Sort the evidence

Write each finding number in one column. A finding may only go in one column, so where it is genuinely mixed, use **Depends** and be ready to say what it depends on.

Supports a later start	Supports keeping 7:45	Depends

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 1 • Commit to a claim

Your claim, in one sentence

Start it with *Ashgrove Middle School should...* A claim must be arguable. If nobody could disagree with your sentence, it is not a claim, it is a fact.

Part 2 • Build it three times

Choose three findings that support your claim. For each, quote or paraphrase the evidence, then write the reasoning sentence that connects it to your claim. The reasoning line is worth more than the evidence line.

Support 1

Evidence (finding #___):

Reasoning — *This matters because...*

Support 2

Evidence (finding #___):

Reasoning — *This matters because...*

Support 3

Evidence (finding #___):

Reasoning — *This matters because...*

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

1. Finding 3 and finding 4 come from the same district. Explain why quoting only one of them would be a weak use of evidence. 3 marks

2. Finding 7 is about teacher sick leave. Explain why it is difficult to use this finding as evidence for either side. 3 marks

3. Finding 8 shows 54 percent of parents in support. Explain one limitation of using that number as your strongest piece of evidence. 3 marks

Part 3 • Write the paragraph

Required structure

Sentence 1: your claim. **Sentences 2 to 7:** three rounds of evidence then reasoning, alternating. **Sentence 8:** a closing sentence that does not simply repeat sentence 1. Do not begin any sentence with *I think* or *In my opinion*. The claim already tells the reader it is your view.

Going Further

Swap paragraphs with someone who argued the opposite claim. Underline their strongest reasoning sentence, not their strongest evidence. Then write one sentence explaining why that reasoning is hard to answer. Finding the best thing about an argument you disagree with is the skill that makes Lesson 17 possible.

Make the Claim

Evidence sort

Supports later start	Supports keeping 7:45	Depends
1 sleep shortfall 3 tardies fell 22% 8 parent majority	2 after school jobs 5 bus cost 6 practice and lighting	4 last period absence 7 teacher sick leave

Finding 4 is frequently placed under “keeping 7:45,” which is defensible. Accept it if the student can explain that the rise in last period absence may not be caused by the time change. Finding 8 in “Depends” is also defensible on sample grounds.

1

They are two results of the same change, and they point in opposite directions. Tardies fell, which supports moving the start, but final period absence rose, which suggests the problem moved rather than disappeared. A writer who quotes only finding 3 is presenting a partial result from a source they have clearly read in full, which is the weakest kind of evidence use because the other half is available to anyone who checks.

Two marks for the opposite directions, one for the point about selective quotation from a single source.

2

Nothing links it to start times. The district has not investigated a cause, so the higher sick leave could come from staffing, building conditions, the age profile of the staff or anything else. A writer could claim early starts exhaust teachers, or claim a later finish would make it worse, and neither claim would have anything behind it. Evidence needs a reasoning line that actually connects, and this finding does not offer one.

Full marks need the idea that correlation is absent, not merely that the cause is unknown. Strong students note that a finding usable by both sides equally is usable by neither.

3

It is a bare majority of a self selected group. Parents who responded are likely the ones with the strongest views or the most flexible schedules, so 260 responses may not represent all families. It also measures preference rather than outcome: what parents want and what would actually work for students are different questions. Fifty four percent against thirty one is a real gap, but it is thin ground for a main argument.

Any one of: self selection, sample size relative to the school, or preference versus outcome, explained properly, earns full marks.

If students ask whether their claim is the right one

Tell them the data genuinely supports both. The findings were built so that a careful student can argue either way, and a student who notices that and says so out loud has understood something most of the class has not. The mark is in the reasoning, not the position, and saying that clearly at the start of the writing time saves ten minutes of hands going up.

Part 3 marking • the paragraph

Full marks looks like this. The claim is arguable and specific. Three findings appear, each followed by a reasoning sentence that answers *so what*. The closing sentence adds something, such as a condition or a priority, rather than restating the opening.

The failure to look for. Evidence with no reasoning. If a sentence names a finding and the next sentence names another finding, the reasoning is missing. Write *why does this matter?* in the margin. That single note, repeated, teaches the skill faster than anything else on this page.

Do not mark the position. Both claims are fully supportable from this data. A student arguing to keep 7:45 with three properly reasoned supports has done better work than a student arguing for 8:30 with three bare facts.

What this lesson is

Students meet a passionate argument that is full of holes, learn a three move rebuttal structure called Concede, Limit, Turn, and practice it. The lesson runs well on its own but is stronger straight after Lesson 16.

Skill

Counterargument. Conceding a real point and then answering it without abandoning the claim.

They hand in

Five identified weaknesses, three concession sentences, four answers, and a full concession and rebuttal paragraph.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 4	Hand out pages. Read the opening script.
4 to 11	Students read the argument on page A, then the worked model beneath it.
11 to 24	Page B. Students find and name five weaknesses in the argument.
24 to 36	Students write three concession sentences using the sentence starters.
36 to 42	Questions 1 to 3 at the top of page C.
42 to 54	Page C. Full concession and rebuttal paragraph on the new topic.
54 to end	Read one paragraph aloud. Ask the class to name where the turn happened.
Short period	Cut questions 1 to 3. Find weaknesses, study the model, then write.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"Most people think winning an argument means never admitting the other side has a point. It is the opposite. The strongest thing you can do is agree with their best point out loud, and then show it does not get them where they think it does."

"The essay on page A argues something plenty of you probably agree with. Read it anyway as a critic, because it argues it badly, and a bad argument for a good position is worse than no argument at all."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"The three moves are Concede, Limit, Turn. Concede: name the true part. Limit: show how narrow that true part actually is.

Turn: explain what follows once it is narrowed. Most students do Concede and then stop, which just hands over the argument."

Stuck?

Say: "Finish this sentence out loud: it is true that _____. Now finish this one: but that only proves _____." Those two sentence stems are the whole structure and saying them aloud is usually enough to unlock the writing.

No copies? Run it this way

Read the argument aloud twice while students list anything that sounds shaky. Write the three moves on the board with the sentence starters underneath. Dictate the page C topic. This lesson survives losing the handout better than most in this pack.

Watch for

Watch for concessions that are not concessions, such as *some people say homework is fine, but they are wrong*. That names an opponent without granting anything. A real concession has to cost something. Ask: *what did you actually just agree to?*

Part 1 • An argument with holes in it

STUDENT ESSAY, EXCERPT

End Homework at Ashgrove

- 1 Homework should be abolished at Ashgrove Middle School. Students already spend seven hours a day in class, and asking for more work at home is simply unreasonable.
- 2 Every student I have spoken to says homework makes them miserable, which proves it does not work. Countries like Finland assign almost no homework and their students perform better than ours, so clearly homework has no educational value at all.
- 3 Teachers only assign it out of habit. If homework were abolished tomorrow, nothing bad would happen.

Part 2 • The three moves

- | | |
|-------------------|---|
| 1. Concede | Name the part of their argument that is genuinely true. Out loud. Without hedging. |
| 2. Limit | Show how narrow that true part really is. What exactly does it prove, and what does it not touch? |
| 3. Turn | Explain what follows once the point has been narrowed, and take the argument back. |

Worked model, answering paragraph 1

Concede. It is true that Ashgrove students already spend seven hours a day in class, and for a student who then works a shift or cares for a sibling, a two hour homework load on top of that is genuinely unreasonable.

Limit. But that is an argument about how much homework is set, not about whether any should exist.

Turn. A twenty minute reading task and a two hour packet are not the same object, and removing both because the second is indefensible would also remove the short, regular practice that makes reading fluent. The problem named in the essay is quantity, and quantity is a problem with a solution that is not abolition.

Why the Limit step is the hard one

Almost everybody can concede, and almost everybody can restate their own position. The move that separates a real rebuttal from a stubborn one is the middle step, where you show exactly how far the opponent's true point actually reaches. A good Limit sentence usually contains the shape *this is an argument about ___ rather than about ___*. If you can fill in those two blanks honestly, the rest of the paragraph writes itself.

Sentence starters you may use

Concede: It is true that... • There is a real point here... • Supporters of this view are right that...

Limit: But that only shows... • This is an argument about ___ rather than ___ • That would be convincing only if...

Turn: Once that is clear... • The real question then becomes... • What actually follows is...

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 1 • Find the weaknesses

The essay contains five clear reasoning problems. Quote the words, then name what is wrong with them.

#	Words from the essay	What is wrong with it
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		

Part 2 • Concede properly

Write a genuine concession for each. It must cost you something. If your sentence secretly disagrees, it is not a concession.

a. To the claim that students are already in class seven hours a day

b. To the claim that homework makes many students miserable

c. To the claim that some teachers assign homework out of habit

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

1. “Every student I have spoken to says homework makes them miserable, which proves it does not work.”

3 marks

Explain the jump in reasoning between the first half of that sentence and the second.

2. The essay uses Finland as evidence. Explain one reason that comparison cannot carry the weight the writer puts on it.

3 marks

3. Explain why conceding a point can make an argument stronger rather than weaker.

3 marks

Part 3 • Your turn

The topic

A group of Ashgrove students has proposed that the school stop giving letter grades and report only written comments. Their strongest argument is this: *letter grades make students focus on the number instead of the learning, and a student who gets a C stops reading the feedback entirely.*

You are arguing against the proposal. That argument of theirs is a good one. You must concede it before you answer it.

Write one paragraph of seven to nine sentences using all three moves. Label them in the margin: C, L and T.

Going Further

Now write the two sentences you would least like to read in response to your own paragraph. Being able to state the strongest objection to your own position is the thing that separates an argument from an opinion.

The Rebuttal

Part 1 • The five weaknesses

#	Words	Problem
1	"Every student I have spoken to"	Unrepresentative sample. A few friends is not the school.
2	"miserable, which proves it does not work"	Does not follow. Enjoyable and effective are different questions.
3	"no educational value at all"	Overreach. One country cannot support an absolute claim.
4	"Teachers only assign it out of habit"	Unsupported claim about motive. <i>Only</i> rules out every other reason.
5	"nothing bad would happen"	Unsupported absolute prediction, asserted not argued.

Accept "simply unreasonable" as a sixth. Any five explained properly is full marks.

Part 2 • Model concessions

a

It is true that a seven hour day is already a full day of concentration, and treating a student's evening as free labor ignores the jobs and siblings many go home to.

b

Plenty of students do find homework miserable, and a task that produces dread every night is not doing what it was assigned to do.

c

Some homework is set out of habit. Worksheets never marked and never referred to again are common enough that most students can name one.

Test each concession by asking whether the opposing writer would accept it as fair. A *but* inside the same sentence means it has turned too early.

1

The first half reports how students feel; the second asserts whether homework achieves its purpose. Those are different claims, joined without argument. Plenty of effective things are unpleasant.

Full marks need both claims named. It is biased is the sample problem, worth one mark.

2

Finland differs in teacher training, funding, class size, starting age and child poverty. Any could explain the gap. Two countries differing on one policy does not establish cause.

One alternative explanation plus the point about isolating a cause.

3

It shows you understood the other side rather than caricatured it, which makes everything else more trustworthy. It also removes their best material before they use it, and forces you to say exactly what remains in dispute.

Any two of trust, pre emptying, forced precision.

Part 3 marking

Mark the Limit hardest. It must narrow the opposing point, not dismiss it. A strong one here reads *that is an argument about how performance is reported, not about whether it should be measured*. Strong Turns usually go to one of three places: comments still rank students, only less transparently; a student who ignores a C may equally ignore three paragraphs of prose; or grades carry information to a parent or next year's teacher that comments do not.

The failure to look for: a paragraph that concedes then restates the original position with more force. If C and T say the same thing either side of a *but*, the Limit is missing.

What this lesson is

Students get a reference table of ten roots, eight prefixes and five suffixes, then meet a passage seeded with words most of them will not know. They take the words apart rather than guessing. The lesson is quiet, individual and has genuinely right answers, which makes it a good choice for a difficult class.

Skill

Morphology. Using roots, prefixes and suffixes to work out unfamiliar words.

They hand in

A completed decode table, six answers, and two invented words used correctly in context.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 4	Hand out pages. Read the opening script.
4 to 10	Students study the reference table on page A. No writing yet.
10 to 18	Students read the passage and circle every word they cannot define.
18 to 34	Page B. Students complete the decode table for eight words.
34 to 44	Questions 1 and 2 on page B, then 3 to 6 at the top of page C.
44 to 54	Page C. Students invent two words and use them in sentences.
54 to end	Collect three invented words on the board. Class decodes them cold.
Short period	Decode four words instead of eight, then go to page C.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"There is a passage on page two with about ten words in it that most of you will not know. You are not allowed a dictionary and you are not going to need one."

"English builds words out of parts, and once you know maybe twenty parts you can take apart thousands of words you have never seen. Study the table first. Then read."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"Try this one on the board. Subterranean. Sub means under. Terra means earth or land. So a subterranean passage is a passage under the ground. You did not learn that word just now. You worked it out, and that is a completely different thing."

Stuck?

Say: **"Cover the middle of the word with your finger. What is left at the front? Find it in the table."** Starting from the prefix is easier than starting from the root and it gets the word moving.

No copies? Run it this way

Write the reference table on the board and leave it up for the whole period. Read the passage aloud slowly, twice, spelling each target word as you reach it. Students build the decode table in their notebooks with four columns. Page C needs nothing but the board table.

Watch for

Some students decode a word correctly and then reject their own answer because it does not sound like a definition they have heard. Tell them their version is allowed to be clumsy. *Under earth passage* is a correct decode of subterranean even though nobody says it that way.

Part 1 • The reference table

Roots

spect	look	cred	believe
dict	say	voc	call, voice
port	carry	terr	earth, land
scrib	write	aud	hear
struct	build	ject	throw

Prefixes and suffixes

re	back, again	circum	around
in, im	not, or into	contra	against
sub	under	ob	in the way of
trans	across	mal	bad
-ible	able to be	-ion	the act of
-ous	full of	-ial	relating to

Part 2 • The passage

The Inspection

- 1 Dr. Reyes presented her **credentials** at the gate and waited while the guard read every line of them twice. She had learned to be **circumspect** at sites like this one. The company had invited her, but an invitation and a welcome are different things.
- 2 The **terrain** beyond the fence was worse than the survey had promised. Loose shale, a slope steeper than any of the diagrams, and somewhere beneath all of it the **subterranean** gallery she had come nine hundred miles to see.
- 3 The foreman was **incredulous**. "You want to go down there today?" His voice was barely **audible** over the compressor. When she did not answer he tried again, louder, and she noticed he did not **contradict** himself, which she counted in his favor.
- 4 Above the shaft entrance somebody had cut an **inscription** into the rock, a date and two initials, worn almost to nothing. Below it a fall of stone **obstructed** half the opening. The rest was clear enough to **transport** equipment through, if the equipment was carried and not wheeled.
- 5 She had spent twenty years in this **vocation** and had never once walked away from a shaft on the first day. The foreman watched her **inspect** the fallen stone, one piece at a time, and said nothing at all.

How to take a word apart

Work from the outside in. Find the prefix at the front, find the suffix at the end, and whatever is left in the middle is the root. Then say the parts out loud in plain words and accept whatever you get, even if it sounds clumsy. **Obstructed** comes out as *built in the way of*, which is not how anyone speaks, and is exactly right.

Now go back and circle any bold word you could not have defined before today.

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 1 • Take them apart

Word	Parts and meanings	Your definition, from the parts
credentials		
circumspect		
subterranean		
incredulous		
audible		
contradict		
inscription		
obstructed		

Part 2 • Questions

1. **Transport** and **inspect** both appear in the passage. Break each into its parts and give the literal meaning. 4 marks

2. The prefix **in** has two different meanings in the table. Using **inscription** and **incredulous**, explain both. 3 marks

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

3. **Vocation** comes from *voc*, meaning call. Suggest why a person's life work might be described using a word that means calling. 3 marks

4. Predict the meaning of **malediction**. You have both parts in the table. 2 marks

5. Predict the meaning of **transcribe**, then suggest what job might involve doing it. 3 marks

6. **Reject** comes from *re* plus *ject*, literally to throw back. Explain how the everyday meaning of reject connects to that. 3 marks

Part 3 • Build two words that do not exist

The rules

Combine at least one prefix and one root from page A into a word that is not a real English word. Then define it from its parts, and use it in a sentence where a reader could work out the meaning from context alone.

Your word	Parts and meaning	A sentence that gives the meaning away

Going Further

Swap pages with a partner. Read only their two sentences, not their definitions, and write down what you think each invented word means. Then check. If your partner guessed correctly, their sentence gave enough context, which is exactly what a good writer does with a hard word.

Part 1 • Decode table

Word	Parts	Meaning from parts
credentials	cred (believe) + ial	Documents relating to being believed. Proof of qualification.
circumspect	circum (around) + spect (look)	Looking around before acting. Cautious.
subterranean	sub (under) + terr (earth)	Under the earth. Underground.
incredulous	in (not) + cred + ous (full of)	Full of not believing.
audible	aud (hear) + ible (able to be)	Able to be heard.
contradict	contra (against) + dict (say)	To say against. To state the opposite.
inscription	in (into) + scribe (write) + ion	Something written into a surface.
obstructed	ob (in the way of) + struct (build)	Built in the way of. Blocked.

Accept clumsy literal definitions. Under earth is a correct decode of subterranean.

1

Transport = trans (across) + port (carry), to carry across. **Inspect** = in (into) + spect (look), to look into.

One mark per breakdown, one per literal meaning.

2

In **inscription**, *in* means into: writing cut into stone. In **incredulous** it means not: not believing. The root has to be checked before deciding which applies.

Both meanings correctly matched for full marks.

3

A vocation is work a person feels called toward rather than work they took. The word carries the idea that something outside the person called them to it, which is why it fits lifelong work. Dr. Reyes travelling nine hundred miles is the passage showing exactly that.

Two marks for being called or drawn, one for lifelong commitment.

4

mal (bad) + dict (say) = a curse. Literally, bad speaking against someone.

One mark for the breakdown, one for a sensible meaning.

5

trans (across) + scribe (write) = to copy out, usually from speech into writing. Jobs: court reporter, medical transcriptionist, captioner, minute taker.

Two marks for the meaning, one for any plausible job.

6

To reject is to refuse and send back. The literal throw back is still visible: an application is thrown back to the sender, a body rejects a transplant by pushing it out.

Full marks need the link between literal direction and modern refusal.

Part 3 marking • invented words

Real parts from page A, a definition that follows from those parts, and a sentence supplying enough context for a reader to work it out without the definition. That third one is where the marks are. Strong student inventions: *subvocal*, *contraspect*, *malstruct*, *transaudible*. If a student invents a word that turns out to be real, tell them so.

What this lesson is

A student draft with twelve deliberate errors, a reference card naming the six error types, and a sentence combining set. There are right answers throughout, students can self check against the key structure, and the whole lesson runs individually and quietly.

Skill

Editing. Naming and fixing six common sentence errors, then combining short sentences.

They hand in

Twelve identified and corrected errors, four combined sentences, and one clean rewrite.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 4	Hand out pages. Read the opening script.
4 to 10	Students study the six error types, then read the draft once straight through.
10 to 28	Page B. Students name and fix all twelve errors.
28 to 40	Set 1 at the foot of page B, then sets 2 to 4 on page C.
40 to 54	Page C. Students rewrite the whole paragraph correctly.
54 to end	Read the corrected version of sentences 1, 3 and 6 aloud so students can self check.
Short period	Do errors in sentences 1 to 6 only, then go to the combining task.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"Every sentence in this draft was written by a real student and every mistake in it is one that turns up constantly. Nobody is being mocked here. These are the twelve errors that cost marks most often, and after today you will be able to name all six kinds."

"Read the whole draft once without stopping. Then go back and hunt."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"The most common one here is the comma splice. Test for it like this. Cover the comma with your finger. If what is on each side could stand alone as a sentence, then a comma is too weak to hold them together. You need a period, a semicolon, or a joining word like and, but or because."

Stuck?

Say: **"Read sentence four out loud. Just that one. Does it sound wrong?"** Sentence 4 has the most obvious error in the draft and hearing it usually starts a student reading the rest aloud, which is where most of the errors become audible.

No copies? Run it this way

Write the draft on the board four sentences at a time and work through them as a class, then leave the remaining eight up for individual work. The six error names go in the corner of the board and stay there. The combining sets can be dictated.

Watch for

Students frequently mark correct sentences as errors once they are in hunting mode. There are exactly twelve. If a student has found fifteen, ask them to rank their finds and cut the three weakest, which is a better use of the time than checking each one.

Part 1 • The six errors

RUN-ON	Two complete sentences jammed together with no punctuation between them.
SPLICE	Two complete sentences joined with only a comma. A comma is not strong enough on its own.
FRAG	A piece of a sentence punctuated as though it were whole. Usually missing a subject or a main verb.
AGREE	The subject and the verb do not match. <i>The tanks was</i> should be <i>the tanks were</i> .
HOMO	Right sound, wrong word. <i>its</i> and <i>it's</i> , <i>their</i> and <i>there</i> , <i>then</i> and <i>than</i> .
VAGUE	A pronoun where the reader cannot tell who or what it refers to.

Part 2 • The draft

The Field Trip • first draft, uncorrected

- 1 Our class went to the water treatment plant on Tuesday, it was more interesting than I expected.
- 2 The guide met us at the gate she had worked there for eleven years.
- 3 Which was longer than I have been alive.
- 4 The tanks was enormous.
- 5 She said the plant cleans forty million gallons a day and that its enough for the whole county.
- 6 When Marcus asked how the filters worked, they explained it twice.
- 7 The smell were worse near the intake.
- 8 Their are six stages in the process.
- 9 We walked along a catwalk above the third tank, the water underneath looked like coffee.
- 10 Then we saw the same water at the end of the process it was completely clear.
- 11 Because I had never really thought about where water goes.
- 12 I would rather visit the plant then sit in class all day.

How to hunt

Read each sentence aloud in your head, on its own, out of order. Errors that are invisible inside a paragraph become obvious in a single sentence. Then check the two most common suspects first: is there a comma holding two whole sentences together, and does every sentence have both a subject and a main verb?

There are exactly twelve errors, one per sentence. Some sentences could be fixed more than one way. Any fix that produces a correct sentence and keeps the meaning is acceptable.

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 1 • Name it and fix it

#	Error	Your corrected sentence
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		
11		
12		

Error codes: RUN-ON • SPLICE • FRAG • AGREE • HOMO • VAGUE

Part 2 • Sentence combining

Combine each set into **one** sentence. Keep all the information. You may add joining words and change word order, and you may cut words that become unnecessary.

Set 1

The bus was late. We waited outside. It was raining.

Two tests worth memorizing

The comma test. Cover the comma. If both sides could stand alone as sentences, a comma is too weak. Use a period, a semicolon, or add a joining word.

The it's test. Read *it's* aloud as *it is*. If the sentence still makes sense, *it's* is correct. If it does not, you want *its*. The same trick works for *you're* and *they're*.

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 2 • Sentence combining, continued**Set 2**

The guide had worked there for eleven years. She knew every valve. She never looked at a manual.

Set 3

The water enters the plant. It is brown. It leaves the plant. It is clear. Six stages do this.

Set 4 • harder

Marcus asked a question. The guide stopped walking. She answered for four minutes. Nobody interrupted her. This was unusual.

Part 3 • The clean rewrite

Rewrite the entire draft as one correct paragraph. Fix all twelve errors and combine at least two pairs of short sentences so it reads as writing rather than as a corrected list.

Going Further

Take any paragraph you have written recently for any subject. Run the same six checks over it and mark anything you find. Most writers repeat two of the six errors far more than the other four, and finding out which two are yours is worth more than getting full marks on this page.

Part 1 • Errors and corrections

#	Error	A correct version
1	SPLICE	...on Tuesday, and it was more interesting than I expected.
2	RUN-ON	...met us at the gate. She had worked there for eleven years.
3	FRAG	Join to sentence 2: ...eleven years, which is longer than I have been alive.
4	AGREE	The tanks were enormous.
5	HOMO	...that it's enough for the whole county.
6	VAGUE	... the guide explained it twice.
7	AGREE	The smell was worse near the intake.
8	HOMO	There are six stages in the process.
9	SPLICE	...the third tank. The water underneath looked like coffee.
10	RUN-ON	...end of the process, and it was completely clear.
11	FRAG	Attach to 10, or: I had never really thought about where water goes.
12	HOMO	...visit the plant than sit in class all day.

Sentences 1, 9 and 10 accept several fixes. A student who used a semicolon has done something more sophisticated than this key and should be told so.

Part 2 • Combining, model answers

Set 1

Because the bus was late, we waited outside in the rain.

Watch for students who just add and twice. Ask which fact is the cause.

Set 2

After eleven years at the plant, the guide knew every valve without ever looking at a manual.

Strong versions turn one statement into a phrase rather than a clause.

Set 3

Over six stages, the water that enters the plant brown leaves it clear.

This set rewards compression. Do not require this exact shape.

Set 4

When Marcus asked his question, the guide stopped walking and answered for four minutes without anyone interrupting, which was unusual.

The hard part is attaching which was unusual to the whole event.

Part 3 marking • the clean rewrite

Count the twelve fixes, then look for at least two genuine combinations. A rewrite that fixes everything but leaves twelve short sentences has done half the task. Expect eight or nine sentences. Small wording changes made for flow are fine and should be encouraged.

What this lesson is

A silent, written version of a class discussion. Students respond to a short text, then pass their page twice, answering what the previous writer actually said. The room stays silent for roughly twenty minutes and the discussion happens entirely on paper.

Skill

Written discussion. Building on other people's ideas in writing rather than in speech.

They hand in

Three written rounds on a shared page, plus a synthesis paragraph and a reflection.

Timing

Clock	What happens
0 to 6	Hand out pages. Read the opening script and the four rules aloud.
6 to 12	Students read the text on page A silently.
12 to 19	Round 1. Students write their own response. Silence begins here.
19 to 26	Pass pages left. Round 2. Respond to what the previous person wrote.
26 to 33	Pass again. Round 3. Read both entries, then add.
33 to 36	Pages return to their owners. Reading time only. Still silent.
36 to 52	Page C. Synthesis paragraph and reflection. Silence may end here.
52 to end	Optional: three volunteers read the best sentence somebody else wrote on their page.
Short period	Run two rounds instead of three and cut the reflection questions.

SAY THIS TO OPEN • WORD FOR WORD IS FINE

"We are going to have a discussion today and nobody is going to speak. Not me either. Everything happens on paper."

"Four rules. One, total silence once we start. Two, you write only on the page in front of you. Three, you must respond to what the person before you actually wrote, not just add your own opinion underneath it. Four, disagreeing is encouraged, insulting is not, and your name goes on everything you write."

SAY THIS PARTWAY THROUGH

"Pass your page to the left now. Read what is already there before you write anything. Your first sentence should refer to something the person before you said. Quote them if it helps."

Stuck?

Point at the four starter stems printed in the box on page B. Students who freeze almost always start moving once they copy a stem and finish the sentence. Do not speak. Tap the box.

No copies? Run it this way

Read the text aloud twice. Students write Round 1 on a sheet of notebook paper with their name at the top, then pass exactly as described. The protocol needs paper and silence, nothing else. This is the best lesson in the pack to run with no photocopier at all.

Watch for

The two failure modes are students writing their own opinion three times without reading, and students writing agreement with no content. Both are fixed by circulating and silently underlining the sentence they were supposed to respond to. Say nothing while you do it.

The text

Everyone Talks, Nobody Listens

- 1 Class discussion is supposed to be the fairest thing that happens in a classroom. Everyone gets a turn. Anyone can raise a hand. The best idea wins because everyone hears it.
- 2 That is not what happens. What actually happens is that the fastest thinkers speak, and speed is not the same thing as depth. A student who needs ninety seconds to work out what they believe will never get to say it, because by second thirty somebody else has answered and the class has moved on. Over a year, that student learns something that has nothing to do with the subject: that their thinking arrives too late to be worth having.
- 3 Meanwhile the students who speak most are not necessarily the ones who understand most. They are the ones most comfortable being wrong out loud. That is a real skill and it is worth something. It is just not the skill anybody claims to be assessing.
- 4 There is a defense of ordinary discussion, and it is a serious one. The world outside school runs on speech. Meetings, interviews and arguments all reward the person who can think while talking, and a school that removes every occasion for that is not preparing anyone for anything. Practicing something uncomfortable is the entire point of practicing.
- 5 So the question is not whether talking is valuable. It is whether the version of talking that happens in classrooms actually distributes the thing it claims to distribute.

What a strong entry looks like

Specific	It names a paragraph number or quotes a phrase. <i>Paragraph 2 says thinking arrives too late to be worth having, and that is the part I keep going back to.</i>
Responsive	In Rounds 2 and 3 it answers the person before you. <i>You said the fast talkers understand more. I do not think the text claims that.</i>
Honest	It is allowed to be uncertain. <i>I cannot decide whether this describes our class or just the classes I dislike.</i>
Yours	It says something you actually think, not the thing you expect to be marked well.

The four rules

- 1 Total silence from the moment Round 1 begins. Including questions to the teacher.
- 2 Write only on the page in front of you. When it is passed, it is no longer yours.
- 3 Respond to what the previous writer actually wrote. Do not simply add a new opinion beneath theirs.
- 4 Disagree as sharply as you like. Never about the person. Sign every entry with your name.

Why silence. In an ordinary discussion perhaps eight people speak and the rest listen. In this one every person in the room contributes three times, nobody is interrupted, and nothing anybody says disappears the moment it is said. The trade is that it is slower and you cannot ask a follow up question. Whether that trade is worth making is the question you will answer at the end of the period.

This page belongs to _____

Class _____

Date _____

Starter stems • use these if you are stuck

You said ___, and I think that is right because... • I disagree with ___ because... • Your point works for ___ but not for... • What you wrote makes me think about...

Round 1 • the owner of this page

Respond to the text. Name the paragraph you are answering.

Signed _____

Round 2 • a different student

Read Round 1 first. Respond to **what that person wrote**.

Signed _____

Round 3 • a third student

Read both. You may side with one of them, or show where they are talking past each other.

Signed _____

Name _____

Class _____

Date _____

Part 1 • The synthesis

Your task

Your page has come back to you. Read all three entries. Then write one paragraph of six to eight sentences that does three things: states where the three of you agreed, states the sharpest disagreement on the page, and gives your own position now that you have read the other two. You must quote at least one sentence somebody else wrote and name them.

Part 2 • Reflection

1. Did anything on your page change your mind, even slightly? If yes, name what did. If no, name the strongest point you still disagree with. 3 marks

2. Paragraph 4 of the text argues that speaking practice matters because the world outside school runs on speech. Explain whether today's silent format answers that objection or avoids it. 4 marks

3. Compare writing this to speaking in a normal class discussion. Name one thing that was better and one thing that was worse. 3 marks

Going Further

Reread only your own Round 1 entry, written before you had seen anyone else's. Underline anything you would now write differently. Then write one sentence on what changed it. Noticing your own position moving, and being able to say what moved it, is a harder skill than defending a position and a more useful one.

The Silent Seminar

Running this one

The silence is the lesson. Protect it.

Students will test it in the first two minutes. Do not answer questions out loud, even procedural ones. Point at the rule box on page A instead. If you speak once the protocol collapses within about ninety seconds. Holding silence for the first three minutes is the entire job; after that it holds itself.

What to do while they write

Circulate silently. When a Round 2 or 3 entry ignores what came before, underline the sentence they should have answered and move on. Say nothing. They correct themselves almost every time.

Time the passes visually, by raising a hand or tapping the board twice. Announce nothing. Students still writing may finish the sentence they are on, not the thought.

If a page arrives blank, tell the receiver in writing to respond to the text directly. Do not make it a moment.

What a strong page looks like

Round 2 names or quotes Round 1. Round 3 does more than agree, either taking a side with a reason or showing the first two are answering different questions. At least one paragraph is referred to by number, and disagreement appears somewhere. Three entries that all agree pleasantly is a weak page and is worth saying so in the margin.

1

Open. Full marks for naming the writer, the point, and what shifted or why it failed to.

Do not reward no, I already knew what I thought. Push for the second half of the question.

2

It partly avoids it. The silent format solves the distribution problem, since everyone contributes and slow thinkers get their ninety seconds, but it does so by removing the very thing paragraph 4 says needs practicing. So it answers the fairness complaint and not the preparation complaint. The best responses call it a supplement rather than a replacement.

Two marks for what it fixes, two for what it does not. A student arguing it genuinely answers the objection can earn full marks with strong reasoning.

3

Open. Better: everyone contributed, nobody was interrupted, there was time to think, ideas could be reread. Worse: slow, tone hard to read, no follow up questions, no way to tell if you were understood.

One mark each for a specific better and worse point, one for naming a real difference rather than a preference.

Marking the synthesis

Three checkable requirements: an agreement identified, the sharpest disagreement identified, and a position that accounts for the other two entries, plus one quoted and attributed sentence. A synthesis that only restates the student's Round 1 position has not done the task, however well written, because the point of the protocol is that reading other people changes what you have to say.

ONE MINUTE, AND IT IS WORTH MONEY

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Volume 2 of this pack exists because teachers wrote about what they wanted next after Volume 1. If a lesson landed well with your class, or one section was too easy, or you wish there were a version for a different grade band, say so. It genuinely determines what gets built.

Two things worth knowing

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Computer Science and Digital Technologies	6 to 8	Ten unplugged lessons. No devices, no logins, no network needed.

Bundles save more than the individual packs

The ELA Volumes 1 and 2 Bundle takes both ELA packs at a discount off the combined price, giving twenty lessons and roughly a month of emergency coverage for one subject. The **Emergency Sub Plans Bundle** takes one pack per subject for the whole grade band. Bundles stay linked to their components, so any future revision reaches you automatically.

Other series

Full Day Sub Plans

Complete days rather than single periods, for Grades 1 to 2 and Grades 3 to 5. Each volume covers three full days across every subject with a read aloud spine for the younger band.

No Lab Required

Ten paper based science investigations for Grades 6 to 8. Built for weekly use rather than emergencies, for classrooms without equipment, budget or lab access.

AI Literacy

Separate units for Grades 3 to 5 and Grades 9 to 12, covering how these systems work, where they fail, and how to use them without outsourcing your thinking.

Digital Citizenship and Online Safety

A three pack spanning Grades 3 to 5, 6 to 8 and 9 to 12. Written for real student behavior rather than for a poster on a wall.

How these are built

Every pack in the store is written by one practicing secondary teacher, not assembled by a team from a template. Passages, data sets and answer keys are original. Every pack is a single PDF with no companion files, no links that can expire and no fonts to install, so it prints identically from any device in any school. Answer keys are written for a non specialist, which means every answer is worked out in full rather than given as a single word.

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Printing notes

Print settings

US Letter, portrait, at actual size. Do not select *fit to page* or *shrink oversized pages*, since both will shift the ruled writing lines. Everything except the cover prints correctly in black and white on a standard copier.

Printing one lesson only

Student pages sit together in every lesson, so a single lesson is always three consecutive pages. Lesson 11 is pages 6 to 8, Lesson 12 is 11 to 13, and each lesson after that follows the same pattern five pages later. The Lesson Index gives the first page of every lesson.

Fonts and construction

Set in Lato and JetBrains Mono. Built as a single US Letter PDF with no external dependencies, so it will print identically from any device without downloading a font or opening a companion file.

Digital Vector

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Emergency Sub Plans • Middle School ELA • Volume 2

Ten no prep emergency lessons for Grades 6 to 8